something to do with Norman, one of Alice's horses. He would gallop towards us as we entered his field to get him in for the evening. The first time I saw this, I turned and ran for my life and hurdled the five-bar gate like Colin Jackson, only to turn round and see Alice rolling about laughing at me!

I had learned to ride horses in Argentina, even though, like skiing and skydiving (which I tried in New Zealand in 2008), it was one of the pursuits forbidden by my ECB contract. It may have led to a questionable show of false confidence on tour in Sri Lanka. We were playing in Dambulla, in the dry Central Province. The stadium, built in 167 days overlooking a reservoir on ground leased from a local temple, held 30,000 but didn't have great training facilities. We staged an improvised shuttle session in a nearby field, and some of the lads were spooked by the sudden interest of several horses. 'Don't worry,' I said as they began to get skittish, 'they're only curious and having a bit of fun.'

Understandably, the session was swiftly abandoned. When I mentioned my calmness in such unfamiliar circumstances to Alice, I thought she would be impressed. 'I would have run away,' she said with a wry smile.

You obviously always have to be careful with farm animals, but luckily enough I never had to report back to cricket with a farming injury, although once a pig somehow managed to butt Alice, splitting her nose and leaving her with two black eyes. You can imagine the comments when she turned up at the families' hospitality box the following day.

She was brought up on the family farm, where they farm sheep, free-range turkeys for Christmas and arable. Since university she has worked on the farm alongside looking after our three children. The farm gave her flexibility, in the form of the odd midweek day off in the early days of our relationship, and a month's grace in later years, when she had the scope to come out on cricket tours.

Visiting cricketers tend to be a reliable source of free help on the farm. Ryan ten Doeschate, my captain at Essex, was the latest cricketer to spend a day worming the sheep. I began by doing odd jobs and now feel as if I know what I'm doing around the farm. Alice still does a lot of work with the sheep, and I help through brute strength and gradually declining ignorance. Without wishing to sound sexist, I've got the muscle to catch a sheep and turn it over, to inspect its feet or check its teeth. It's easier for a bloke to do more of the physical element of the work.